

## 1.1 Introductory Remarks Pp 10 - 12

A commentary, explanation, and amplification of the book "The Orthodox Faith, Worship, and Life, Orthodox Catechism: An outline" These notes are intended to be watched or read in conjunction with reading chapters in this excellent book. Sometimes, there are things unsaid that a beginner might not understand, so we have attempted to fill in some of the gaps that we have seen in the catechumens we have taught. This book is very deep, and you should read it slowly and look at the references. One of the problems with books, in my opinion, is they give a reference, but then they don't give you the text. Even when the text of a scripture or other quotation is shown, you might want to look at the context.

VIDEO: <https://youtu.be/p4a7NjKAAZ4>

AUDIO: [http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/catechism\\_2024+orthodox-faith-worship-and-life-orthodox-catechism-010-012.mp3](http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/catechism_2024+orthodox-faith-worship-and-life-orthodox-catechism-010-012.mp3)

TEXT: (differs slightly from video and audio)

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## Contents

|                                                                                                                  |   |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---|
| 1.1 Introductory Remarks Pp 10 - 12 .....                                                                        | 1 |
| Page 11: "No One has seen God" .....                                                                             | 1 |
| Page 11: "Faith is man's answer to the Revelation concerning God. " .....                                        | 2 |
| A good primer on how to have increased faith. ....                                                               | 3 |
| Page 11: "Faith is the unshakable belief in the existence of things we hope for." .....                          | 4 |
| Page 12: "Therefore being justified by faith, let us have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ..." ..... | 5 |
| Page 11: "Faith is the synergy of men in the ministry of his salvation." .....                                   | 6 |
| Page 12: "Faith is the beginning of salvation and life in Christ." .....                                         | 6 |

### Page 11: "No One has seen God"

In the very first chapter, the author quotes Saint John the Theologian, who says, "No one has ever seen God. The only-begotten son, who is in the bosom of the Father, He has made Him known. (John 1:18)

In this short quotation, there is a depth of theology. It is that way with all of the scripture, but especially the Gospel of John. The term only-begotten should be familiar to you; it is used in the "Symbol of Faith". We have always believed that the Son is only-begotten of the Father. This dogma is in the Gospel, and in a formal way, the things that were in the Gospel about the Son, the Father and the Spirit were written down more than 300 years after the Apostles, in the fourth century, when the church was attacked by heresies that challenged the Apostolic teaching.

St John says that the Only-Begotten Son is in the bosom of the Father. This means that He is equal to the Father - He is of one Essence with the Father. Being in the bosom of the Father, he knows the Father, and therefore He is able to make Him known to us.

Page 1 of 7 C:\Dropbox\www\orthodox.net\catechism\catechism\_2024+orthodox-faith-worship-and-life-orthodox-catechism-010-012.docx

The vast majority of our prayers are addressed to Jesus Christ, although the majority of those prayers close with an invocation of the Holy Trinity. Why do we pray to Jesus Christ so much? Why do we say the Jesus prayer which is: "Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy on me?" Why don't we say a prayer to God the Father over and over? We pray to Jesus Christ so much because His incarnation reveals the Father to us. God is ineffable and unknowable, and we can only experience Him through His energies, but we can see Jesus Christ because He became a man, so Jesus Christ has made the knowledge of God accessible to us.

When the Theologian says that "No one has seen God," he is referring to the essence of God. We know God only through His energies, and these energies, only through the purification of the soul, are accessible and even, visible. These energies are also referred to as light: "God is light and in Him is no darkness at all" (1 John 1:5) "Blessed are the pure in heart for they shall see God." (Matthew 5:8)

A huge difference in the mystical theology of Orthodoxy and, if it even exists, the mystical theology of Protestantism and Roman Catholicism, is that we know with full assurance that we are born to experience the energies of God. As we become purified, we are able to see these energies which are all over the universe, but invisible to the impure. When we are fully perfected, we will have achieved Theosis - union with God - and we will see God as much as we are able to see Him by being bathed in His light. His light is not a terrestrial light; it is actually his presence by which He communicates with us and leads us to know all things about Him.

**As you are pursuing "salvation", remember that it is nothing less than knowing God.** It is not just being forgiven or going to heaven. It is being transformed so that we are perfect, and to be in the presence of God and understand Him. Our idea of salvation so much bigger than anything else expressed among others that call themselves Christian. Since it is so big, it should completely consume our life, and we should struggle to become perfected. This is the reason why we have commandments that we must follow. They are not externally imposed but rather our internal requirements to open ourselves up to the understanding of who God is.

Page 11: "Faith is man's answer to the Revelation concerning God. "

I really like this quotation because we should learn to see everything in life as a question. We should also see every revelation of God, especially all dogmas, to be something that requires us to react. All dogma is moral in content. It is not just facts about something.

I preach about this all the time; even the rhetorical questions in the Gospels and in all the Scriptures should be answered, and we should see everything as a question. When we encounter a temptation, there is a question! The question is: "What you going to do, are you going to live as a Christian or not?" Or perhaps the

question is: “Do you have faith?” Everything is a question, and everything must be answered. Therefore, if we are living by faith, we are constantly answering questions.

We must scrub from our mind the idea that faith is just belief. The Protestant so-called “reformers” had that problem. For them the expression of Christianity was believing something. For us, **faith is belief experienced**. Faith is acting upon belief and having our belief increase because of our actions and gradual perfection.

[A good primer on how to have increased faith.](#)

The gospel gives us an account of the Apostles asking the Lord to increase their faith. “And the apostles said to the Lord, “Add faith to us.” But the Lord said, “If ye have faith as a grain of mustard, ye would say to this sycamine tree, ‘Be rooted out and be planted in the sea’; and it should obey you. <sup>7</sup> “But which of you, having a slave plowing or shepherding, will say to him when he cometh in from out of the field, ‘Straightway, come forth and recline at table’? <sup>8</sup> “But will he not say to him, ‘Make ready what I might sup on, and gird thyself, and be serving me while I eat and drink; and after these things thou shalt eat and drink’? <sup>9</sup> “He doth not have gratitude toward that slave because he did the things which were commanded him, doth he? I think not. <sup>10</sup> “Thus also ye, whenever ye have done all things which were commanded you, say, ‘We are unprofitable slaves, for we have done that which we were bound to do.’” (Luke 17:5-10)

Here we have a good primer on how to have increased faith.

The first principle is that **“it is better to do a little than not to do a lot.”** A mustard seed is very tiny, but if it is planted in the ground it becomes a great tree. Therefore, we should not denigrate our small efforts. We should not be happy and static with having only small efforts, but we must do something small before we can do something big. So if you try to pray the prayers for the morning and you can't finish them, then do some of them! If you're bad at fasting, at least fast in some way! If it's hard for you to find time to read the Gospels, read something! And humble yourself, and you'll get better.

The other principle is **knowing our place**. Our Lord gives the example of a slave who is working, and when he comes home, he doesn't expect his master to serve him. We have a master and we serve Him! And we should consider everyone else to be our master, after a fashion. We should submit ourselves to others even those that we consider to be inferior to us. It is not a sin to understand that some people are inferior to us, depending on the context. We know that a child is inferior in understanding to us. We might know that someone with a mental illness cannot perceive reality as we perceive it. We're not judging these people, but we should be aware of their limitations and serve them.

An example of something that will increase your faith is to play some game with your child when you don't feel like doing it. That is obedience to their needs, and that will build faith.

The final quote of this excerpt is critical for us to inculcate in our hearts. Even if we do something good we're unprofitable. Orthodox Christians are not afraid to think of themselves as unprofitable slaves. It does not give us a complex. It's just the truth, however, that we are unprofitable slaves to a Master Who loves us and will help us to become profitable. So let's not take credit for anything we do that is good and let's not overly blame ourselves for that which is bad. If we do something bad, we should try to get better; if we do something good, we should thank God that we were able to do something.

Page 11: "Faith is the unshakable belief in the existence of things we hope for."

This assertion is absolutely true, but we must understand it in an Orthodox way. Faith is always believing in something that we experience in some way even if we do not see it. It is ridiculous to believe in something that does not exist. We cannot know something exists unless we are aware of it in some way. We are aware of God because we feel Him moving within us. We don't see Him, or hear Him, but we know He is there. We know He is there because we respond to His energies, and make moral changes.

The so-called "reformers" twisted faith into something that was only an exercise of the mind. We Orthodox Christians do not just believe things; we also act upon our belief in these things. And as we change morally, and struggle to follow the commandments, and fall down, and get up, our faith in God becomes even more unshakable because of our experience.

Our faith is weak, and we certainly need it to be increased. It increases in a myriad of ways because God communicates with us in a myriad of ways. He communicates it to us through the movements in our hearts, and the Holy Spirit speaking to us interiorly, according to the Holy Apostle Paul: "Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities: for we know not what we should pray for as we ought: but the Spirit itself maketh intercession for us with groanings which cannot be uttered." (Romans 8:26)

He communicates to us when we have troubles and temptations and either overcome them or fall to them. He communicates with us with us through the advice of and interaction with others. He communicates with us through the beauty of the sunset or sunrise. He often communicates with me when I look at one of my beautiful grandchildren. He certainly communicates with us, and may it be that we are attentive to what he is saying, when we read the Scriptures or pray in the services.

In short, God communicates with us in everything if we have eyes to see and ears to hear.

One could say that the process of salvation is a continual effort to experience God. This is why I harp so often on the need to do prostrations and read the Psalter and the Gospels and the lives of the saints and other spiritual reading. When we do these things we are exposing ourselves to things which increase our faith.

Every time I see the word “hope” and talk about it, I feel constrained to remind speakers of English that our use of hope in the vernacular is not the Christian usage of hope. We speak of “hoping” to get a good grade on a test. That means that we are not sure if we are going to do well but we “wish” that we would do well. There is no “wishing” in Christian hope. **Christian hope is knowing that something is going to happen and desiring it with all of our heart and *working* towards it. And it is impossible to have this hope unless we are also experiencing something regarding the thing that we hope for.** We must nurture hope in our life. The best way to do this is to do nothing passively. If we believe that Jesus Christ is our Savior, then we should actively, aggressively, try to follow Him and become like Him. If we only believe things mechanically or intellectually, this is not hope, and when there are temptations, our belief will fall away, just like the seed that is sowed in shallow (rocky) ground, and dies when there is a drought. (See Matthew 3: 3-17)

Page 12: “Therefore being justified by faith, let us have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ...”

The full quote from Romans on page 11: “Therefore, having been justified by faith, ***let us have peace*** with God through our Lord Jesus Christ, through whom also we have had access by faith into this grace in which we stand, and we boast in the hope of the glory of God.”

It is important to note that sometimes translations really matter. The King James translation and many others like it would have St. Paul saying: “we *have* peace”, when actually he is saying something that requires action and effort: “***let us have peace.***”

Here we see the synergy of man’s will with God’s. Our ability is tiny, but God respects it and requires of us that we struggle to follow the commandments. He does not impose the commandments on us nor does He impose righteousness upon us. We become righteous because “we have had access by faith into this grace in which we stand”. Blessed Theofylact teaches regarding this verse: “But what is the grace? All the benefits we accrue through baptism. Wherein we stand, because we are steadfast and immovable.”

After receiving baptism, we stand in the grace we receive, that is, we work. It takes work to stand. A standing position is a position of readiness and action. This is a large hurdle for many people who have been indoctrinated into the idea that salvation is wholly dependent on *what we think*. Salvation is dependent on what we think only if we think of obeying God and loving Him and following the commandments *and* follow through on these thoughts!

Another way of speaking of synergy is as St. John Chrysostom did, quoted on page 11: “He everywhere refers to both components: *his part and our part*. That which Christ brings, however, is multifarious and diverse, for He died for us and reconciled us and brought us to God and give us grace ineffable; we brought faith only as our contribution.”

Page 5 of 7 C:\Dropbox\www\orthodox.net\catechism\catechism\_2024+orthodox-faith-worship-and-life-orthodox-catechism-010-012.docx

Since the Western understanding of faith is so warped, I must put a disclaimer and a clarification. When St. John says that we “brought faith only as our contribution” he understands faith in the Orthodox way, which we are trying to explicate in this little essay. *Faith is to believe and act on that belief. When we bring only faith, we are only bringing all of ourselves, which is all that we can give to God.*

If you are an inquirer into the Orthodox faith or a catechumen fully committed to being baptized, or for that matter, an Orthodox Christian of 80 years standing, you must put in your head and keep it in your heart that you are committing to working to follow the commandments and to obtain perfection after the grace of baptism has been granted to you. There is nothing passive about the Christian life! It is an active life, and the process of living it is even described as: “Now the kingdom of heaven suffereth violence, and the violent take it by force.” (Matthew 11:12) The violence you must perform is upon your passions and sins. This is warfare to the death. There are no shortcuts, but there is “grace in which we stand,” and this grace, that is, God’s presence in our life, is enough to overcome everything.

Page 11: “Faith is the synergy of men in the ministry of his salvation.”

This inspired quotation from the book *cannot be over emphasized*. Synergy implies that we have a part and God has a part. Our faith is active and living, and not static. It is not only of the mind, but it is of our whole being. All of your life you will need to struggle to put your actions in line with that which you say you believe.

Page 12: “Faith is the beginning of salvation and life in Christ.”

For adult converts, there is first some small amount of faith, and then baptism, and then our faith grows as we stand and work. When infants are baptized, they of course have no faith yet, but God gives them grace so that when they become reasoning beings, they will grow in faith.

Immediately after your baptism and for the rest of your life, there will be struggles and temptations. And God will help you in all of them if your faith is an active faith and not just something in your head. Let’s look at some more of the passage from Romans and the commentary of Blessed Theofylact. It’s a little bit difficult to understand, but it’s inspiring and beautiful. By the way, you should get accustomed to reading things that are difficult, and taking your time with them. Don’t be overwhelmed. Just keep on reading and God will bring you understanding. Baptism is to embark upon a beautiful journey to perfection. Every journey has its difficulties, and because God has begun the journey for us, we will reach our destination.

“Therefore being justified by faith, let us have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ: by whom also we have access by faith into this grace wherein we stand, and rejoice in hope of the glory of God.” Romans 5:1-2

Paul now speaks concerning our conduct. He has already said a great deal in favor of faith and at the expense of works, and so in order that we may not grow complacent, he now speaks about how we ought to live: **“Now that we have been justified by faith, let us no longer sin, but rather let us have peace with God by living a life that is pleasing to him.”**

“How can we do that? Through our Lord Jesus Christ. For he who justified us while we were still sinners will work with us to preserve us in his righteousness, since it is by him that we have access in the first place. **If he brought us near while we were still far away, then how much more will he hold onto us now that we are near!** Now it is into this grace that he has given us access. How so? By faith, that is, “by the faith that we bring with us.”

...

““And not only so, but we most in afflictions also: knowing that affliction worketh out patience; and patience, a tested character; and a tested character, hope: and hope maketh not ashamed.” Romans 5:3-5

“We glory not only in the blessings to come, but more than that, we glory even in tribulations (or, afflictions) that now beset us. Do not be dismayed when we suffer tribulations—they are the boast of a Christian.” But how? Because tribulation worketh patience; and patience makes a man experienced in withstanding temptation. And armed with this experience, with confidence that he has undergone tribulation for the sake of God and with a clear conscience, he looks forward in hope to receiving the rewards of those tribulations. And such hope does not fail and maketh not ashamed the one who hoped—such a thing is impossible with God. For he who gives the blessings is immortal and good, and we who are to receive them, even though we die, yet shall we live.

Therefore, there is nothing standing in the way of our hopes coming to fruition. Because the love of God is shed abroad in our hearts by the Holy Ghost which is given unto us. Paul confirms these future blessings by the love which God has already shown us. What he means is something like this: **‘Do not doubt that our hope in God’s blessings will not fail. For if he loved us so much that he should make us sons of God already by the Holy Ghost, without any toil on our part, how shall he not also give us crowns won by our toil?’** The love of God is shed abroad in our hearts, meaning, ‘We see how lavish and abundant it is, for we have in our hearts the Spirit he has given unto us.’” (Commentary of Blessed Theophylact on Romans, available from Amazon (<https://www.amazon.com/Explanation-Romans-Blessed-Theophylact-Ochrid-ebook/dp/B0CRC7G4CH/>) in Kindle and paperback) and <https://www.oceanitissa.com.au/shop> and <https://www.lulu.com/search?page=1&q=nun+christina> )

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